

presented themselves as champions of gender equality. In reality, the idealized expectations of American and Russian women were not completely realized in either country. In the US, women entered the workforce in increasing numbers and campaigned for equality. In the USSR, wage differentials persisted and the workforce was largely segregated by gender, with women given junior roles; women who had performed jobs in heavy industry during the war years were moved to lighter industries such as textiles.

Space women

One field of endeavor where Soviet women appeared to shine, however, was the Space Race, as the US and Russia

competed to be the first to explore the new frontier. In 1963, Russian cosmonaut Valentina Tereshkova, a 26-year-old former textile worker, became the first woman to go to space—20 years before the first female American astronaut. After intensive training with four other women for 18 months, Tereshkova was picked to pilot Vostok 6. She spent three days in space and orbited Earth 48 times. However, ultimately Tereshkova's mission seemed to be mainly for propaganda purposes and the USSR abandoned the training of female cosmonauts in 1969. The Russian government claimed, according to Tereshkova, that the dangers were too great for women. The USSR did not recruit further female cosmonauts until 1980.

Meanwhile, in the US, female scientists helped to forge the country's space program. Several women were among the team behind the launch of Explorer 1, the first US satellite to orbit the earth, in 1958 (following Russia's Sputnik 1 and Sputnik 2 the previous year), and scientists such as Barbara Paulson, a founding member of the team at NASA, helped develop the first probes to the moon and planets. Yet women were not initially considered suitable astronauts; they were largely perceived as underqualified and physically unfit for space travel. All of the 13 female pilots who trained to become astronauts for the Mercury 13 mission in 1963, who had outperformed some of their male counterparts in tests, were dropped from the mission. It was not until 1983, and NASA's seventh shuttle mission, that the first American woman, Sally Ride, entered space on the space shuttle Challenger. According to the Challenger commander, Robert L. Crippen, she was selected for her expertise in operating the shuttle's arm to deploy and retrieve satellites. Ride spent six days in space, paving the way for other female astronauts. After the mission, she devoted much of her time to encouraging girls to follow in her footsteps.



▲ American dream

After World War II, the US promoted the image of the perfect housewife—an attractive woman who kept the home clean, cooked for her family, and raised her children behind a white picket fence.



In 1969, the USSR had
775,000
women engineers,
almost as many as
the total number of
engineers in the US.